cement, iron and steel, and hydro-electric companies. For almost three and a half decades, Purshotamdas was concerned with the activities of almost every joint-stock company worth the name in Western India. This ‘corporate octopus’ as Frank Moraes has described him, was associated with over fifty companies as Chairman or Director for many years with the number reaching nearly seventy in the 1930s and 1940s. He was associated with BEST Co. Ltd., Indian Cable and Radio Communications Ltd, and Tata companies like TISCO and Tata Power Company. Purshotamdas was also associated with the House of Killicks and was Director of the Kohinoor Mills, the Ahmedabad Electricity Co. Ltd, and was also on the Board of the Surat Electricity Co. to name only a few. He also played an important role in rescuing TISCO in 1924 when his intervention induced Lord Reading, the Viceroy, to vote ₹50 lakh in the form of debentures to help rescue the company from its financial crisis.

Cotton was at the core of Purshotamdas’s business and his career was inextricably intertwined with the foundation, history, and progress of the East India Cotton Association Limited for nearly three and a half decades. He built up the cotton trade into one of the best organized and disciplined commodity markets in the country. His pioneering contribution was acknowledged when the Association passed a proposal which envisaged that two statues of Purshotamdas be installed, one at the Cotton Exchange, Marwari Bazaar, and the other at Cotton Green. A statue was unveiled at Cotton Green on May 29, 1952, by the then Chief Minister of Bombay, Morarji Desai. The second statue could not be installed for want of suitable space near the Cotton Exchange Building, Kalbadevi. Since suitable space could not be found for many years, it was decided to install the statue shortly after Purshotamdas’s death on July 4, 1961[6], in the Trading Hall of the Association at Kalbadevi.

Another institution with which Purshotamdas’s career was intertwined for more than three decades was the Oriental Government Security Life Assurance Company. He joined its Board in 1919 and in 1933 became its Chairman. For twenty-two years he led the organization to record achievements until his resignation in 1955 following differences with the Board over the mutualisation of the company. In 1933 when he assumed charge as Chairman, the company’s business was ₹48 crores but by 1955 when he retired it had risen to ₹237 crores, and in the year preceding his